

Book proposal form

Thank you for your interest in publishing with us.

The following questions are designed to provide a clear picture of your proposed book, which will help us to evaluate the potential publication. Please complete the questions as precisely as you can and provide a short CV of each author/editor.

Please note:

- We ask for sole consideration of your proposed book. If you have submitted this proposal to any other publisher, please let us know.
- All entries should be in the language of your proposed book.
- By making use of our [Search Engine Optimization \(SEO\)](#) guidelines you can help potential readers to easily find your book. The SEO Tips for Book Authors will support you in drafting key essential book information in this form (such as title, back cover copy, unique selling points, etc.) to attract a targeted audience.
- Please do not include hyperlinks in this form besides your email address.

***Mandatory field**

Corresponding Author/Editor

First name*

Last name*

Please consider that this is how your name will appear in the book.

Email*

ORCID iD

We recommend registering a unique identifier to identify you from other researchers with similar names. You can register at orcid.org. e.g. 0000-0001-5000-0007

Institution

Department

City*

State

Country*

Co-Author(s)/Co-Editor(s)

Additional Author(s)/Editor(s)

In case of co-authors or co-editors, please provide detailed information (name, address, etc.)

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Biography*

Please provide a short biography highlighting any personal and/or professional details relevant to your research proposal e.g. related research experience, work experience, previous books etc. Ideally this should be 2-3 paragraphs. It would be very helpful if you could provide your CV.

About your Book

By making use of our Search Engine Optimization (SEO) guidelines you can help potential readers to easily find your book. The [SEO Tips for Book Authors](#) will support you in drafting key essential book information in this form (such as title, back cover copy, unique selling points, etc.) to attract a targeted audience.

Proposed Title *

Please enter the provisional title of your book.

Titles should precisely describe the content. Avoid catchy titles that readers will not find when searching online or titles which may mislead readers to another topic. Utilize main keywords when creating a title and note that only 50 characters are displayed in most search results.

Power, Language and Urban Sustainability

Subtitle

Toward a Performative Planning Theory of Urban Policy

Originality of work*

Please note that if your work has been previously published by an other publisher you will need the rights to publish in print and digital formats. Please check with the original publisher regarding their re-use policy.

New



Type of book*

Monograph



Is this an authored or edited work?

Authored: I am the only Author/have a co-author.



Length

Please state the following:

Estimated number of pages in the book*

If you can provide the number of words in the book, please include this in the additional text field at the bottom of this form.

Approx. 320 pages (approx. 110,000 words)

Estimated number of black and white figures to be included

20

Book proposal form

Estimated number of color figures to be included

8

Whether the book will contain electronic supplementary material



Yes



No

Submission date*

Please indicate the date on which you expect to submit the complete manuscript.

Month

December

Year

2027

Table of contents*

Please provide a list of all preliminary chapter titles in the field below. In addition, please provide your table of contents with further details as well as a sample chapter, if available. Ideally this should be a chapter by chapter synopsis of the project. We recommend you state the chapter title and three or four sentences per chapter explaining the planned contents. For edited works, please also provide the tentative list of contributing authors. If you do not have that level of detail yet, please enter as much information as possible.

PART I - FOUNDATIONS: WORDS, POWER AND THE CITY
 1. Introduction: Why Urban Sustainability Is a Problem of Power and Language
 2. Power in Planning Theory: From Rational Control to Communicative, Foucauldian and Agonistic Readings
 3. Language in Planning Theory: The Communicative, Argumentative, Discursive and Narrative Turns
 4. How Plans Do Things with Words: Speech Acts, Performativity and the Sustainability Performativity Gap
 PART II - THE FELICITY FRAMEWORK FOR URBAN SUSTAINABILITY
 5. Authority: Who Is Entitled to Speak Sustainability? Expertise, Legitimacy and Recognised Speech
 6. Articulation: The Grammar of Sustainable Cities - Labels, Frames, Storylines and Modality
 7. Translation: How Sustainability Travels Across Scales, Sectors and Languages
 8. Materialisation: From Policy Words to Urban Worlds
 PART III - CONTESTED AND EMERGING ARENAS
 9. Counter-Speech: Insurgent Narratives, Agonism and the Re-politicisation of Sustainability
 10. Plural Languages, Plural Sustainable Cities: Southern and Decolonial Perspectives on Planning Discourse
 11. Algorithmic Speakers: Generative AI, Large Language Models and the Automation of Planning Discourse
 PART IV - METHODS AND PRACTICE
 12. The Sustainability Speech-Act Audit: A Method for Critical Planning Linguistics
 13. Applying the Framework: Comparative Case Studies of Urban Sustainability Plans
 14. Conclusion: Toward a Performative Planning Theory for Just Urban Sustainability

Description of the Book*

Using the [SEO Tips for Book Author's](#) please provide a descriptive text of what the book is about, keeping the target audience in mind. What are the main topics? Why are they important/relevant? What problem do you set out to solve? Max. 3000 characters including spaces. Please note that the first two sentences are the most enticing for readers and should be to the point, succinct and relevant. We suggest starting the first sentence with "This book offers/provides etc..." and ending the text with a short description of the target audience.

This book offers a new theory of how power and language shape urban policy and decide whether urban sustainability goals are achieved or remain empty words. Cities worldwide publish plans promising sustainable, resilient, smart and liveable futures, yet a persistent gap separates what these plans say from what they deliver.

Planning theory has long debated power through communicative, Foucauldian, agonistic and post-political perspectives, and it has taken discursive and narrative turns to study language. Yet these debates remain fragmented: power and language are rarely analysed together, and planning theory still lacks an account of how policy words become material urban outcomes. This book fills that gap by developing a Performative Planning Theory. Drawing on speech-act theory, critical discourse analysis, narrative analysis and policy mobility research, it treats plans, strategies and sustainability commitments as speech acts whose force depends on power.

Its core contribution is the Felicity Framework for Urban Sustainability. The framework identifies four conditions under which sustainability language performs, or fails to perform: Authority (who is recognised as entitled to speak), Articulation (the vocabulary, framing and grammar of policy), Translation (how ideas travel across scales, sectors, languages and algorithms) and Materialisation (how words become law, budgets, infrastructure and measurable change). The book explains why sustainability so often works as a vague, consensus-building idea that depoliticises urban conflict, and how counter-narratives and insurgent practices can re-politicise it.

The book also opens two new frontiers for planning theory. First, it examines linguistic diversity and epistemic justice, showing how the dominance of English-language sustainability vocabularies marginalises local and Southern knowledge. Second, it treats generative artificial intelligence and large language models as new "speakers" in planning, asking who holds authority and accountability when machines draft plans and summarise public voices.

Moving from theory to practice, the book introduces the Sustainability Speech-Act Audit, a step-by-step method with coding templates that researchers and practitioners can use to assess the performative strength of urban plans. Comparative case studies show the method in use.

Written for researchers, graduate students and lecturers in urban planning, urban studies, human geography, public policy, sustainability science and critical discourse studies, the book is also a practical resource for planners, policymakers and civil society organisations working to turn sustainability commitments into real change.

Keywords*

Using the [SEO Tips for Book Authors](#) please enter between 5 and 20 keywords that when typed in a search engine will increase the chances of your book appearing amongst the top results. Max. 64 characters including spaces per keyword. Avoid one-word keywords by using strings of text (E.g. Sustainable development initiatives in Australia).

Planning theory and power relations; Language and power in urban planning; Urban sustainability policy discourse; Critical discourse analysis of urban plans; Performativity and speech acts in planning; Communicative planning theory and its critics; Foucauldian analysis of urban planning; Agonistic and post-political planning; Narrative and storytelling in urban planning; Sustainability implementation gap in cities; Policy mobility and translation of sustainability; Epistemic justice in urban planning; Southern and decolonial planning theory; Generative AI and large language models in planning; Depoliticisation of urban governance; Smart, resilient and sustainable city discourses; Participatory planning and public engagement; SDG 11 sustainable cities and communities

Book proposal form

Unique Selling Points*

Please enter 3-5 one-line bullet points describing what makes your book unique and appealing. (E.g. provides a comprehensive review of the rapidly expanding field of X, includes in-depth discussions on Y, covers a vast array of special topics and applications illustrating the wide use Z.). Max. 120 characters including spaces per line.

Use speech-act verbs or the active voice when writing USP texts.

- Introduces Performative Planning Theory, linking power and language to explain why sustainability plans succeed or fail
- Builds the Felicity Framework: authority, articulation, translation and materialisation of sustainability language
- Equips readers with the Sustainability Speech-Act Audit, a ready-to-use method with templates for analysing plans
- Extends planning theory to generative AI and large language models as new speakers in urban policy
- Centres linguistic diversity, Southern perspectives and epistemic justice in urban sustainability debates

Audience/market*

What is the intended market/readership?

Research



Competing titles

Please list (including author, title and publisher) those publications that your primary readership is currently buying or using. What are the key benefits of your work compared to those publications you have listed? Where do they overlap and how do they differ?

1. Flyvbjerg, B. *Rationality and Power: Democracy in Practice* (University of Chicago Press, 1998). Landmark study of power in planning; a single case, not focused on language or sustainability.
 2. Hajer, M. *The Politics of Environmental Discourse* (Oxford University Press, 1995). Classic on storylines and discourse coalitions; national environmental policy, predates urban sustainability agendas, the SDGs and AI.
 3. Healey, P. *Collaborative Planning: Shaping Places in Fragmented Societies* (Palgrave Macmillan, 1997; 2nd ed. 2006). Foundational communicative text; critics argue it underplays power.
 4. Fischer, F. and Forester, J. (eds) *The Argumentative Turn in Policy Analysis and Planning* (Duke University Press, 1993); Fischer, F. and Gottweis, H. (eds) *The Argumentative Turn Revisited* (Duke University Press, 2012). Edited volumes on policy argumentation in general, not urban sustainability.
 5. Gunder, M. and Hillier, J. *Planning in Ten Words or Less: A Lacanian Entanglement with Spatial Planning* (Ashgate, 2009). Closest on "sustainability" as an empty signifier; psychoanalytic, with no empirical method.
 6. Ameen, L. *The Narrative Turn in Urban Planning* (Routledge, 2020). Narrative typology from Helsinki; power and sustainability are secondary.
- Key benefits: this book (a) brings power, language and sustainability together in one framework; (b) adds speech-act and performativity theory to explain the gap between saying and doing; (c) offers a reusable method with templates; (d) covers multilingual and Southern contexts and generative AI, which none of the titles above address. Overlap: it builds on these works as foundations and speaks to the same readers in planning theory and policy analysis.

Open access

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Please indicate if your research was funded, and if applicable provide the name of the funder.

- ☐ Not funded
- ☐ Funded (Name of funding organization/institution)

Please indicate if you are interested in making your publication available open access.

- ☐ My funder requires open access publication
- ☐ Open access publication is not required, but I wish to explore this route
- ☒ I am not required/do not wish to publish open access

Book proposal form

Is there anything else you would like to bring to our attention regarding this proposal?

For example a preferred book series, potential textbook courses or any other information requested by your Springer Nature Editor.

If available, please provide any other extra material supporting your proposal such as sample chapter(s), bibliography or any other manuscript material in PDF or Word format.

To learn more about the benefits of becoming a Springer Nature author/editor visit our [website](#).

Preferred series: The Urban Book Series (Springer). Alternative: Sustainable Development Goals Series.

Estimated length: approx. 320 pages / 110,000 words, 14 chapters in four parts.

Electronic supplementary material: coding templates, a codebook and worked examples for the Sustainability Speech-Act Audit.

Course adoption: graduate and upper-undergraduate courses in planning theory, urban policy and governance, sustainability planning, and discourse and policy analysis.

Supporting material: a chapter-by-chapter synopsis and a literature-gap bibliography are attached; a sample chapter (Chapter 4) can be provided on request.

Thank you for taking the time to fill out this form.

On submission, your proposal will be read by the appropriate commissioning editor who will, if necessary, discuss it with colleagues and/or send it for review by one or more external advisers chosen by us for their specialist and/or market expertise. After the initial assessment, we will contact you to let you know how we wish to proceed.

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